



Movie Management

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A few years ago, when MP3s enjoyed all the hype, globally there was a deluge of audio content. People accumulated thousands of MP3 tracks and didn't know how to manage them. Tracks were repeated in collections and strewn about over the hard disk. Most of all, listeners didn't get quick access to the songs they were in the mood to hear. A similar type of situation has risen once again, but this time for movies – driven not by a diminishing file size, but by ever expanding storage space. By now, you may have accumulated hundreds of files that need to be sorted, categorised and managed. Often, you don't even know the movies you have, which one you've seen, and to what genre a particular movie belongs. Consider the situation where you have friends over, and they're all in the mood for an action flick. Which one should you play? The file names alone don't really ring a bell. Well fear not, for movie management applications are here to help you.

Several paid as well as free-licence programs that perform a multitude of functions are available these days. These applications catalogue your movies, keep track of titles you have lent out (in the case of DVDs), let you browse movies by various parameters such as actor, director, genre, etc., and most will even look up movie information from online databases such as IMDb. Some have their own database such as Coolector. Sadly, after going through several, we are yet to discover one that covers everything, especially in the realm of freeware.

We have, however, zeroed in on one that fulfills most of our needs – Rock Solid Software's MovieManager. You can download it at <http://movie-manager.ca/WindowsSetup/Freeware/MovieManagerSetup.exe>. It's free to use and whatever little lacunae there are can

be worked around with a bit of tweaking.

General interface

The application provides two viewing modes – by movies or by actors. The movies perspective is preferable. On the left half of the screen you have a list of movies that are currently in your database. On the right, one pane shows you details such as IMDb rating, duration and genre. The bottom pane displays the movie poster and the cast.

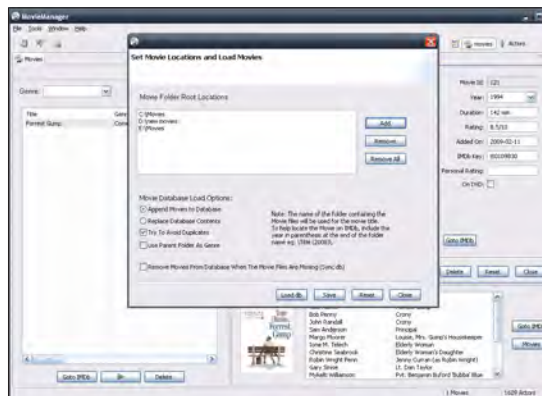
Adding movies

The MovieManager database can be populated in several ways. When you run the application for the first time, the list is blank. Click the + icon to open a movie editor tab on the right pane. You can key in the name of the movie and click the IMDb lookup button. The details will be automatically filled in. Click Save when done.

Scanning for movies

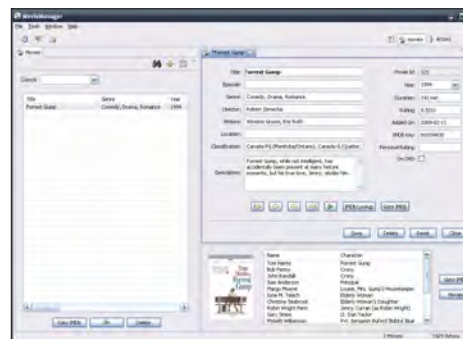
Scanning for movies is a better way to add movies to your database. Before scanning, go to Tools > Properties and click the Load Database tab to add file types. We found MKV and BIN to be missing from the list. To scan your hard drive, go to Tools > Load Movies. Click on Add to select your movie folders. If you wish to synchronise your database with your current collection, then check the Replace Database Contents button. If you want to sort your movies into genres, check the 'Use Parent Folder As Genre' box. Click the Load db button to scan. Your movies will now appear in the list. Click on the IMDb lookup icon to get information for the movies. You may have to clean up the names of the files as they may contain more than just the movie name. The software, however, pulls info more easily if folder names have a date of release. Therefore, use the following format for folder names – <Movie Title> (<year>).

Often, we feel the need to share some great movies we have with our friends. How do you let them know the movies that constitute your awesome collection? Simple, just mail them an HTML list of your database! The generated HTML page contains the movie title



Scanning your hard drive for movies

and other fields that you have selected including the picture, rating, etc. The list can be sorted by genre too. To create an HTML list go to Tools > Generate HTML. Here you can choose the order and the details that you want. The default name for the file is MOVIES.html and will be saved on the desktop. Click Generate once done.



Scanning your hard drive for movies

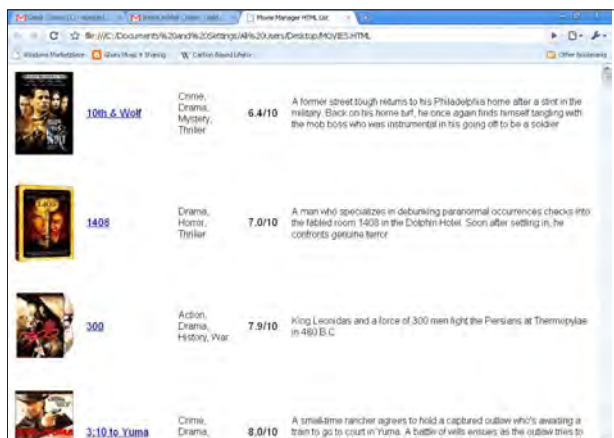
Listing parts played by a particular actor

Suppose you want to know all movies in your database with John Travolta. In the movie view, double-click on the actor's name on the right hand side pane. The view will automatically shift to 'actors' view and will display movies featuring John Travolta in the bottom pane. Double-click on any of those fields to bring up a tab of that movie.

Seen / Unseen

You can save two different databases for movies you have seen or have yet to see. To do this, click on File > Backup Database and save it in a new folder called seen / unseen. Maintain separate folders for the two categories. ■

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HTML page of your movies